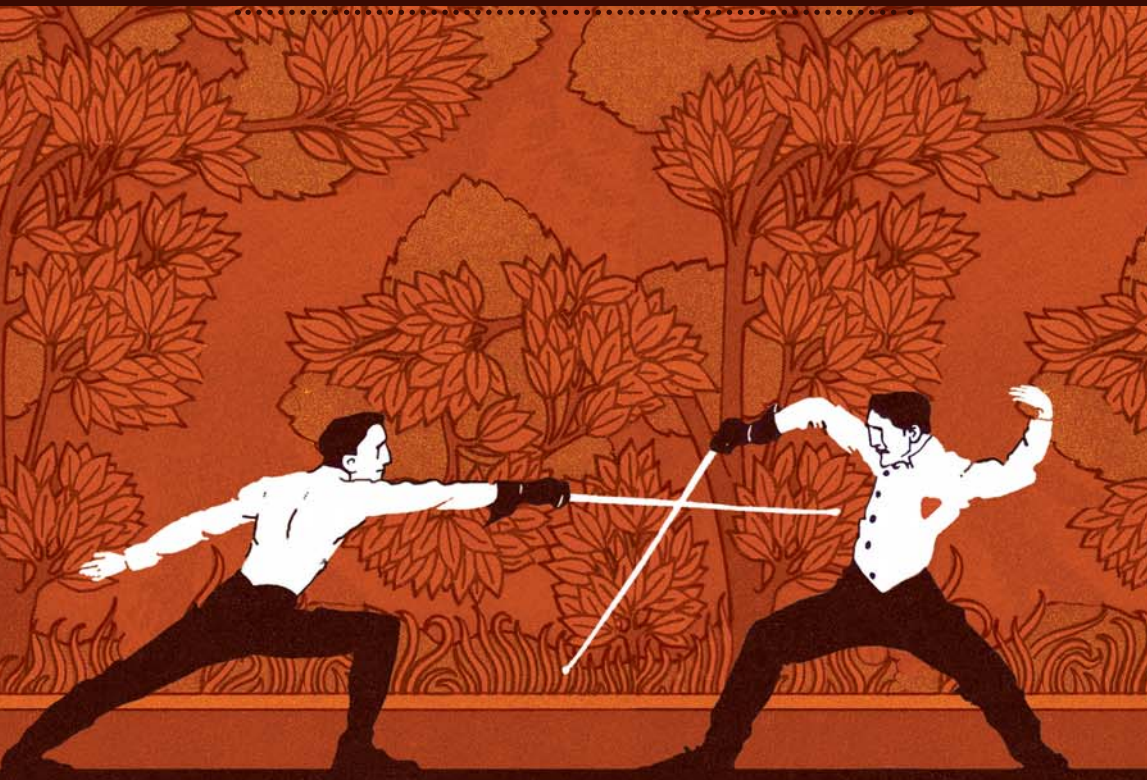
ELEMENTS *of* FICTION WRITING



CONFLICT & SUSPENSE

JAMES SCOTT BELL

INTRODUCTION

Trouble is my business.

—Raymond Chandler

Once you get a character with a problem, a serious problem, "plotting" is just a fancy name for how he or she tries to get out of the predicament.

—Barnaby Conrad

You tell stories.

You tell stories because you want people to read them.

You want readers to be moved, entertained, maybe even enlightened.

You want to tell stories that wrap readers up and get them lost in a world you've created, with colorful characters and plots that don't let up.

It doesn't matter what genre you write in. You want all these things happening because that's what makes the magic connection in this alchemy we call fiction.

Yes, that's it. You want to make a little magic.

You can, you know.

Most aspects of the craft of writing fiction can be learned. You can practice them and put them to work for you.

Frankly, I get a little miffed when someone says fiction writing can't be taught. That would come as news to all the young writers who were instructed by teachers, editors, books, and articles. People like John Grisham, who dined monthly on *Writer's Digest* magazine.

Or me, reading Lawrence Block's fiction column as if it were holy writ. And then trying the things he wrote about and seeing how they worked on the page.

I've also taught countless writers in conferences and through books on the craft, and have seen many of them break into print.

So don't buy into the idea that this craft doesn't have tools and techniques that will make you better.

What can't be taught is what you bring to your fiction—your inherent talent, background experiences, passion, and heart. The singular *you*.

But talent and experience mean nothing if they don't find an expression on the page that readers can relate to.

Craft teaches you how to connect with readers so they can get lost in your stories.

And what gets them lost?

It really comes down to one thing: characters who are in trouble.

It doesn't matter what kind of trouble it is so long as it is of great importance to the story people. When a reader describes getting "caught up" in a novel, it's just shorthand for saying that trouble is happening to a character, or group of characters, and the reader wants—no, *needs*—to see what happens.

Alfred Hitchcock said it this way: *A great story is life, with the dull parts taken out.*

A scene without trouble is a dull part. A character who is not caught up in trials and dangers and challenges and obstacles—interior, exterior, or both—is not going to excite us for very long.

It doesn't matter who the character is, either. A quirky, colorful character overstays her welcome after a few chapters, unless trouble comes calling.

So trouble is your business. And conflict and suspense are the tools of the craft that will take your business to the readers.

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WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?

The greatest storytelling experience of my life occurred when I was in high school. A friend of mine ran the film club and arranged a showing of Alfred Hitchcock's *Psycho*. I'd never seen the movie before. Not on television or anywhere else.

For the screening, he booked the auditorium and showed the film at night.

The place was packed.

And when the lights went down and the movie started, the place was electric with anticipation.

Some who had seen the movie before knew when to scream.

They screamed when Janet Leigh first arrives at the Bates Motel.

Of course, when she takes her infamous shower, the screams were all over the place. Maybe even I screamed. I couldn't hear myself. But I was so caught up in the movie by that point I didn't really notice anything else but my own pulse. I was gripped by the power of Hitchcockian suspense. I was in a dream.

When Martin Balsam started walking toward the house, the screams were intense. When Vera Miles started toward that same house, the screams could have cracked plaster. And they didn't stop till the end of the movie.

I'm telling you, that's the way to see *Psycho* for the first time. Not on television. Not alone. See it at night, in a crowded theater. If there is thunder and lightning outside, so much the better.

That's the feeling you should be going for. Not scream-out-loud suspense necessarily but the kind that holds you in its grip and won't let go.

The kind that has the readers asking, *What happens next?*

That's suspense. And every novel needs it.

In an interview, best-selling author Sandra Brown said, "Suspense is another essential. That doesn't necessarily mean the 'Boo!' kind of suspense. Every novel should have suspense. It's the element that keeps the reader turning the pages. I try and pose a question, subliminally, to my reader on the first page if possible, and I withhold the answer to that question until the very final pages. New questions arise along the way, and they're gradually answered as the story unfolds. But that main, overriding question, the one that makes a story out of a mere idea, is the last one to be answered."

Suspense in fiction creates a feeling of pleasurable uncertainty. The reader doesn't know what's going to happen, but is compelled to keep reading to find out. That feeling must, of course, permeate a genre thriller; but it is just as essential for a character-driven or literary novel. Unless readers feel pleasurable uncertainty, the story will drag.

Suspense is *the delay of resolution*. It's from the French, meaning to "cause to hang." You are letting the answer hang out there, and readers keep going to find out when the hanging thing will finally be resolved.

The more emotionally involved the reader is with the hanging question, the more worry generated about the characters and therefore the greater the degree of suspense.

A character might be looking for his pajamas. Where are they? That question is hanging in the air, but it's unlikely to generate a whole lot of reader concern.

Unless, of course, his pajamas are where he has the note that is the key to the mystery, and some cleaning service took them while he was asleep.

That's the goal: to create such a bond with the characters in a plot of high stakes that the reader has to know how the whole thing shakes out—and to do it for the whole length of the book.

In this section, we will take suspense apart and look at it from all angles.

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN MYSTERY AND SUSPENSE

Both mystery and suspense are tools of compelling fiction. It's helpful to know the difference so you can better judge your strategy. Here's a start:

Mystery = who did it?
Suspense = will it happen again?

Mystery is like a hedge maze as you go from clue to clue.
Suspense is like the trash masher in *Star Wars,* closing in.

Mystery is about "figuring it out."
Suspense is about "keeping safe."

Mystery is a puzzle.
Suspense is a nightmare.

Mysteries ask, *What will the lead character find next?*
Suspense asks, *What will happen next to the Lead character?*

There is a lot of crossover here. A thriller can have a central mystery, as in *The Da Vinci Code.* And a mystery can have plenty of suspense, as in *The Big Sleep.* A deft handling of both elements makes for a hugely pleasurable reading experience.

THE STRANDS OF SUSPENSE

In chapter four, I talked about the Golden Gate Bridge in San Francisco. You know those giant cables that drape over pylons? Those super-heavy-duty cables are actually made up of many smaller ones, twisted together.

And that's a good way to think of suspense, too. Different strands working together to support the whole.

I like to think of suspense in the following ways:

Macro Suspense

Since suspense is the withholding of resolution, your novel must hold a sense of suspense from beginning to end. The readers must be turning the pages because they *need to find out what happens.* If you have set up the story with the right stakes—death on the line—the big question is, *Will the character make it out of this alive?*

Without macro suspense, nothing else you do in your individual scenes will matter. The readers will simply not care.

You might have written the best chase scenes in the history of literature, but if there is no sense that the POV character is in real trouble, the chase is of little moment.

In *Velocity*, Dean Koontz sets up a dizzying dilemma for the ordinary guy Lead, Billy Wiles. Coming out to his car after a bartending stint, he finds this note:

> If you don't take this note to the police and get them involved, I will kill a lovely blond schoolteacher somewhere in Napa County.
>
> If you do take this note to the police, I will instead kill an elderly woman active in charity work.
>
> You have six hours to decide. The choice is yours.

What kind of sick joke is this? Billy, rattled by it, takes the note to his policeman friend, who says it's a prank. Forget about it. Billy tries, but when six hours has passed, Billy wonders, has someone been murdered? Surely not.

And we wonder, too. But Koontz doesn't give the answer. Billy goes into work the next day, and as he goes about his routine we can't help wondering if there has indeed been a murder.

Koontz can make us wait now, string us along as he will, because he has set up a hugely suspenseful premise.

Can you formulate a macro suspense sentence, one that sums up all the stakes for the Lead throughout the novel? If you've done your work on *death* as the stake, you should be able to do it.

Will Scarlett survive the Civil War, save her home, and find true love at last? (*Gone With the Wind* by Margaret Mitchell)

Will Dr. David Beck find his wife, thought to be dead for eight long years? (*Tell No One* by Harlan Coben)

Will Prince Albert be able to overcome his stutter in time to rally his people against the Nazi menace? (*The King's Speech,* screenplay by David Seidler)

Try it for your novel now and keep that sentence handy as a reminder.

Scene Suspense

Each individual scene should have suspense, and each can if you build upon the character's fears and worries. There is something unresolved in the scene, namely the outcome. The character has entered the scene with an objective (and this, in turn, is related to his overall objective in the novel). He

encounters obstacles in the scene, so we wonder if he will come out of the scene successfully or unsuccessfully.

In the film *The Graduate,* based on the novel by Charles Webb, Benjamin Braddock has called Mrs. Robinson to meet him at a hotel. He has made the fateful decision to accept her offer—of herself.

In the scene at the hotel, Ben's objective is to meet with Mrs. Robinson without being noticed. But he has obstacles. Like the suspicious desk clerk who asks him if he's here "for an affair." Ben is aghast. "The Singleman party?" the clerk offers. Ben is relieved. But only for a moment.

Later, when he goes to the same clerk to get a room, there is more suspicion, such as Ben's only luggage being a toothbrush.

Here Ben knows what the obstacles are, and his fear factor is whether he'll be exposed as having an illicit tryst with an older woman, the wife of his father's partner, no less.

In *Gone With the Wind* there's a terrifying escape from the burning of Atlanta. The suspense comes from the questions, Will Scarlett get out of there with the pregnant Melanie? Get out before the mob steals her horse? Get out before fire falls on her and kills her? The suspense of this scene matters because we know the stakes for Scarlett in the overall story. This is her world coming apart, and she is the only one in her family who seems to have the strength to salvage some of it.

Hypersuspense

Hypersuspense happens when the character does not know what the forces are that oppose him—and neither does the reader.

You are part of the story along with the Lead, looking to figure out what's going on. When you write in first-person POV, it's almost automatic if you withhold answers from the Lead.

In du Maurier's *Rebecca,* the narrator recounts the story as it happened, not giving us the benefit of her knowledge right away (since she's the one telling it, she could have come right out and said, "Here's the deal on Rebecca …" but where is the fun in that?).

Contrast that with one of the best-selling novels of the 1970s, *Love Story.* It begins with the first-person narrator telling readers that this is the story of a girl who died.

Does that dissipate the hypersuspense? No, it just shifts the focus. *How* did she die? We get the love story first, before we get to the death.

But you can also accomplish the same thing in third-person POV, just by keeping it close and limited. Follow one Lead throughout. Don't reveal anything else to the reader from another POV.

If you do use multiple POVs that clue the reader in, you can always keep the Lead in the dark as he tries to figure out who is opposing him.

Paragraph Suspense

The smallest unit for suspense purposes is the paragraph. Think of each one as having the possibility of withholding information or ramping up tension. For example:

> Roger turned the corner onto Spring Street. The day was bright and clear and he could see City Hall in the distance. The tower, with its pyramid-shaped cap, reminded him of something. Yes, that was it. The hood ornament he'd seen on Crandall's car. That night at the beach. What did it mean? Crandall was there all along!

Maybe that works for you and maybe it doesn't. But upon reflection you might decide you want to stretch out the suspense even further:

> Roger turned the corner onto Spring Street. The day was cloudy and dark. He could barely see City Hall. The pyramid-shaped cap, visible in the muck, reminded him of something. What was it? What? It was there, on the edge of his mind. Reel it in, bring it closer. It was *something.* Something important. But he couldn't get it.

Dialogue exchanges are also made up of paragraphs, and offer further opportunity for suspense and stretching tension. We'll cover that in chapter 18.

Every novel, of every genre, offers increasing possibilities for suspense. If you keep in mind the various strands available, it will soon become second nature for you to exploit them skillfully. You'll be writing page turners.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

James Scott Bell is the best-selling author of more than twenty novels, and is a Christy Award winner for *Final Witness* in 2000. His fiction has been reviewed in *Publishers Weekly*, *Booklist*, *Library Journal*, and the *Library Review*. He's the author of *Write Great Fiction: Plot & Structure*, *Write Great Fiction: Revision & Self-Editing*, and *The Art of War for Writers*. He writes for *Writer's Digest* magazine. Bell has taught fiction writing courses at Pepperdine University and is a regular on the conference circuit. His website is www.jamesscottbell.com. He lives and writes in Los Angeles, California.

WRITING REFERENCE

RAMP UP THE TENSION AND KEEP YOUR READERS HOOKED

Inside you'll find everything you need to know to spice up your story, move your plot forward, and keep your readers turning pages. Expert thriller author and writing instructor James Scott Bell shows you how to craft scenes, create characters, and develop storylines that harness conflict and suspense to carry your story from the first word to the last.

Learn from examples of successful novels and movies as you transform your work from *ho-hum* to *high-tension*.

- Pack the beginning, middle, and end of your book with the right amount of conflict.
- Tap into the suspenseful power of each character's inner conflict.
- Build conflict into your story's point of view.
- Balance subplots, flashbacks, and backstory to keep your story moving forward.
- Maximize the tension in your characters' dialogue.
- Amp up the suspense when you revise.

Conflict & Suspense offers proven techniques that help you craft fiction your readers won't be able to put down.

BONUS ONLINE EXCLUSIVE:

Download a free PDF of Bell's in-depth conflict analysis of his novel *No Legal Grounds* at writersdigest.com/conflict-suspense.

About the Author

James Scott Bell is the best-selling author of more than twenty novels, *Write Great Fiction: Plot & Structure*, *Write Great Fiction: Revision & Self-Editing*, and *The Art of War for Writers*. Learn more at www.jamesscottbell.com.

US $16.99

W1600

ISBN-13: 978-1-59963-273-5
ISBN-10: 1-59963-273-X

51699

EAN 9 781599 632735

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UPC 0 35313 65351 3